Lesson 03 material: Pronunciation: Vowels

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

1.5: Vowels

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Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/01%3A_People_and_Places/1.05%3A_Vowels
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Audio for this section is saved on your computer in `E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\01.05-vowels`: Bed Bad practice 1; Bed and bad listening practice 2; Bed and bad practice 3; Bed and bad vowel sounds; Ship and Sheep listening practice 5; Ship and Ship Listening Practice 1; Ship and Ship Listening Practice 3; Ship and sheep listneing practice 4; Vowel Sounds Ship and Sheep; Vowel Sounds Ship and Sheep Listening Practice 2

Introduction to Vowels

There are 5 vowels in the English alphabet: A E I O and U. Each vowel has a long and a short sound.

Watch the Video

Scratch Garden: Vowel Sounds

Watch the video about vowels and then take a short quiz to review what you've learned.

Video: https://youtu.be/4TjcT7Gto3U

Quiz

Use the information in the video to answer the questions. Select the correct answer, click "check" to see if your answer is correct, and then click the arrow to move to the next question. When you have answered all of the questions, click "Finished."

EXERCISE

1. How many vowels are in the English alphabet?
a) 2 b) 5 c) 26 d) 10

2. How many sounds does each vowel have?
a) 2 b) 5 c) 26 d) 10

Fill in the missing letters

The five vowels in English are A, E, I, _____ and _____.

Fill in the missing word

Each vowel sound has a long sound and a _____ sound.

3. An example of a short "a" sound is the A in____.
a) apple b) acorn

4. An example of a long "a" sound is the A in____.
a) apple b) acorn

5. An example of a short "e" sound is the E in____.
a) elephant b) eagle

6. An example of a long "e" sound is the E in____.
a) elephant b) eagle

7. An example of a short "i" sound is the I in____.
a) insect b) island

8. An example of a long "i" sound is the I in____.
a) insect b) island

9. An example of a short "o" sound is the O in____.
a) ostrich b) oatmeal

10. An example of a long "o" sound is the O in____.
a) ostritch b) oatmeal

11. An example of a short "u" sound is the U in____.
a) umbrella b) unicorn

12. An example of a long "u" sound is the U in____.
a) umbrella b) unicorn

Resources: American English Phonemes

- American English Vowels
- American English Diphthongs
- Access an Interactive American English Phonemic Chart with sounds and examples.
- For Teachers: Watch the video Introduction to Teaching Pronunciation Workshop - Adrian Underhill to learn the sounds in the phonemic chart.

Minimal Pairs: Ship and Sheep

Sometimes it is difficult to hear the difference between two vowel sounds. For example, the "i" in "ship" and the "ee" in "sheep" may sound very similar to you. The words "ship" and "sheep" are minimal pairs because they only have one sound that is different.

Warm Up: What do you see?

What do you see in each of these pictures? Tell your partner.

(Picture: a white sheep looking at the camera) (Picture: an old ship sailing on the ocean) (Picture: a stick figure of a man slipping on a banana) (Picture: a road covered in ice or sleet with a car parked on the side of the road)

Figure: Photos by Sam Carter on Unsplash, Austin Neill on Unsplash, OpenClipart-Vectors from Pixabay, and Clay Banks on Unsplash

Can you say it?

Read the tongue twister:

The sheep on the ship slipped on the sheet of sleet.

- Can you say it 3 times quickly? Practice saying the sentence quietly to yourself or with a partner. Then try to say it 3 times quickly in front of the class.
- What do you notice about the sounds in the words: sheep, ship, slip, sheet, and sleet?

Sounds /ɪ/ and /iː/

Figure: The image above includes a picture of a ship and a sheep with instructions about how to form the sounds /ɪ/ and /iː/ using your mouth.

Rules to Remember

Rules to Remember: Ship vs. Sheep

To form the sound /ɪ/ as in "ship":

- Open your mouth a little.
- Don't stretch the sides of your lips out.
- Make the sound in your throat.

To form the sound /iː/ as in "sheep":

- Open your mouth a little.
- Smile: Stretch the sides of your lips out as far as you can.
- Make the sound in your throat.

Listen and Repeat

Read the words in the table below. Listen and repeat the words. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Vowel Sounds Ship and Sheep")

/ɪ/	/iː/
pill	peel
mitt	meat
fit	feet
lick	leak
hill	heel
chick	cheek
it	eat

Listening Practice 1

You will hear two words from the table above. If the words are the same, write "S." If the words are different, write "D." (Audio on the lesson web page: "Ship and Ship Listening Practice 1")

Example:

- If you hear "pill . . .pill" write S.
- If you hear "pill . . . peel" write D.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

Vowel Sounds Answers 1.docx

Listening Practice 2

Listen. Circle the word you hear. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Vowel Sounds Ship and Sheep Listening Practice 2")

1. pill / peel
2. mitt / meat
3. fit / feet
4. lick /leak
5. hill / heel
6. it / eat
7. chick / cheek

Vowel Sounds Answers 2.docx

Pair work

Work with a partner. Partner A, read one of the words (example: say either "pill" or "peel"). Partner B, point to the word you hear. Do this for 1-7 and then switch roles.

Listen and Repeat

Read the words in the table below. Listen and repeat the words. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Vowel Sounds Ship and Sheep Listening Practice 2")

/ɪ/	/iː/
fill	feel
ship	sheep
lip	leap
hit	heat
bin	bean
live	leave
slip	sleep
Tim	team

Listening Practice 3

You will hear two words from the table above. If the words are the same, write "S." If the words are different, write "D." (Audio on the lesson web page: "Ship and Ship Listening Practice 3")

Example:

- If you hear "fill . . .fill" you write S.
- If you hear "fill . . . feel" you write D.

1. _____

2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

Vowel Sounds Answers 3.docx

Listening Practice 4

Listen. Circle the word you hear. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Ship and sheep listneing practice 4")

1. fill / feel
2. ship / sheep
3. lip / leap
4. hit / heat
5. bin / bean
6. live / leave
7. slip / sleep
8. Tim / team

Vowel Sounds Answers 4.docx

Pair work

Work with a partner. Partner A, read one of the words (example: say either "pill" or "peel"). Partner B, point to the word you hear. Do this for 1-7 and then switch roles.

Game Time

Jump to the left/ jump to the right

Stand in a straight line facing the white board. Students should stand directly behind or in front of their classmates. The teacher will write the /ɪ/ sound on the left side of the board and the /iː/ sound on the right side of the board. The teacher will read some of the words you've been practicing. Jump to the left when you hear the /ɪ/ sound and jump to the right when you hear the /iː/ sound.

Listening Practice 5

You will hear sentence a or sentence b. Put an X next to the correct reply. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Ship and Sheep listening practice 5")

Number	Listen. Do you hear sentence a or sentence b?	Put an X next to the correct reply.		
1	a. Did you feel the pot?	b. Did you fill the pot?	_____ Yes, it's hot. Ouch!	_____ No. It was already full.
2	a. She wants to live here.	b. She wants to leave here.	_____ Yes, it's a beautiful place.	_____ I know. She hates this place.
3	a. Did the baby sleep?	b. Did the baby slip?	_____ Yes, thank goodness! He was tired.	_____ Yes, he fell, but he's ok now.
4	a. Is that your mitt?	b. Is that your meat?	_____ Yes, I like to play baseball.	_____ No, I'm a vegetarian.
5	a. Is that an orange pill?	b. Is that an orange peel?	_____ Yes, that's my medication.	_____ Yes, I had fruit salad for breakfast.
6	a. That's a tall hill.	b. That's a tall heel.	_____ I know. It's going to be hard to climb.	_____ I know. These shoes are hard to walk in.

Vowel Sounds Answers 5.docx

Check

Check your answers with the class. Then practice saying both sentences and replies.

Picture Dictionary

Words you might need to know.

(Picture: a baseball mitt with a baseball in it)

Figure: a baseball mitt. (Photo by Ben Hershey on Unsplash).

(Picture: A person peeling an orange. The orange peels are in the foreground.)

Figure: an orange peel (Image by congerdesign from Pixabay)

(Picture: high heel sandals)

Figure: a shoe with a high heel (Image by Adriano Gadini from Pixabay)

(Picture: orange and white pills spilling out of a pill container)

Figure: orange pills (Image by Christina Victoria on Unsplash)

Practice Speaking

Work with a partner. Look again at each sentence. Student a, say sentence a or b. Student b, say the correct reply. Then switch roles.

Recording: /ɪ/ and /iː/

Practice reading each of the 12 sentence above. Have a friend read the answer to each sentence. Focus on making the /ɪ/ and /iː/ vowel sounds long and clear. When you're ready, record yourself and submit your recording to your teacher.

Notice Sounds in Real-World English

Watch the video "25 Things to do in Berlin." Remember to click the CC button so you can read the subtitles. Find at least 3 words with the /ɪ/ sound and 3 words with the /iː/ sound. Write them in the table below.

Video: https://youtu.be/lw5NHQeXzpA

/ɪ/	/iː/

Some Possible Answers - ship and sheep.docx

Spelling

Look at the list of words you've made with your class.

1. How do you spell the /ɪ/ sound?
2. How do you spell the /iː/ sound?

Minimal Pairs: Bed and Bad

Sometimes it is difficult to hear the difference between two vowel sounds. For example, the "e" in "bed" and the "a" in bad may sound very similar to you. The words "bed" and "bad" are minimal pairs because they only have one sound that is different.

Warm Up: What do you see?

What do you see? Tell your partner.

(Picture: tents and a camp site) (Picture: a lamp lit in the dark)

Figure: Images by Tommy Lisbin on Unsplash and Photo by Vladimir Fedotov on Unsplash.

Can you say it?

Read the two sentences:

The man met his friend by the tents at the camp. "I can't see," said the man. But the friend didn't let him light the lamp.

- Underline the /e/ and /æ/ sounds in the sentences above.
- Practice saying the sentence quietly to yourself or with a partner. Practice making the /e/ and /æ/ sounds long and clear.

Rules to Remember

Rules to Remember: Bed vs. Bad

To form the sound /e/ as in "tent":

- Relax and open your mouth a little.
- Stretch the sides of your mouth out just a little more than you did for the /ɪ/ sound.
- Make the sound in your throat.

To form the sound /æ/ as in "camp":

- Relax and open your mouth a little.

- Drop your jaw slightly.
- Make the sound in your throat.

Listen and Repeat

Read the words in the table below. Listen and repeat the words. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Bed and bad vowel sounds")

/e/	/æ/
bed	bad
said	sad
set	sat
celery	salary
men	man
mess	mass
left	laughed

Listening Practice 1

You will hear two words from the table above. If the words are the same, write "S." If the words are different, write "D." (Audio on the lesson web page: "Bed Bad practice 1")

Example:

- If you hear "bed. . .bed" write S.
- If you hear "bed . . . bad" write D.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____

Bed bad Vowel Sounds Answers 1.docx

Listening Practice 2

Listen. Circle the word you hear. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Bed and bad listening practice 2")

1. bed / bad
2. said / sad
3. set / sat
4. celery / salary
5. men / man
6. mess / mass
7. left / laughed

Bed bad Vowel Sounds Answers 2.docx

Game Time

Jump to the left/ jump to the right

Stand in a straight line facing the white board. Students should stand directly behind or in front of their classmates. The teacher will write the /e/ sound on the left side of the board and the /æ/ sound on the right side of the board. The teacher will read some of the words you've been practicing. Jump to the left when you hear the /e/ sound and jump to the right when you hear the /æ/ sound.

Listening Practice 3

You will hear sentence a or sentence b. Put an X next to the correct reply. (Audio on the lesson web page: "Bed and bad practice 3")

Number	Listen. Do you hear sentence a or sentence b?	Put an X next to the correct reply.

1	a. Is that dead?	b. Is that Dad?	_____ I think you killed, it.	_____ Yes, that's him.
2	a. Did you see the mess of papers?	b. Did you see the mass of papers?	_____ Yes, you need to clean that up.	_____ Yes, there were a lot of papers.
3	a. They left.	b. They laughed.	_____ Why did they leave?	_____ I don't think it was very funny.
4	a. She met the man at the cafe.	b. She met the men at the cafe.	_____ Was it a date?	_____ How many men were there?

Bed bad Vowel Sounds Answers 3.docx

Check

Check your answers with the class. Then listen and repeat both sentences and replies.

Practice Speaking

Work with a partner. Look again at each sentence. Student a, say sentence a or b. Student b, say the correct reply. Then switch roles.

Recording: /e/ and /æ/

Practice reading each of the 8 sentence above. Have a friend read the answer to each sentence. Focus on making the /e/ and /æ/ vowel sounds long and clear. When you're ready, record yourself and submit your recording to your teacher.

Notice Sounds in Real-World English

Watch the video "25 Things to do in Berlin." Remember to click the CC button so you can read the subtitles. Find at least 3 words with the /e/ sound and 3 words with the /æ/ sound. Write them in the table below.

Video: https://youtu.be/lw5NHQeXzpA

/e/	/æ/

Some Possible Answers - Bed and Bad.docx

Spelling

Look at the list of words you've made with your class.

1. How do you spell the /e/ sound?
2. How do you spell the /æ/ sound?
3. Why can you hear the /æ/ sound in "can't" but not in "can"? (Examples: We can't come to the party. / We can come to the party.)

Links on the original page

- American English Vowels: https://easypronunciation.com/en/american-english-pronunciation-ipa-chart#american_english_vowels
- American English Diphthongs: https://easypronunciation.com/en/american-english-pronunciation-ipa-chart#american_english_diphthongs
- Introduction to Teaching Pronunciation Workshop - Adrian Underhill: https://youtu.be/1kAPHyHd7Lo